we needed was the “plus” vote, the incremental vote that can make all the difference in an election,’ is how the strategy was explained to me by a Modi adviser.

Just days after being officially made the BJP’s prime ministerial candidate, Modi addressed his first ‘mega rally’ in Haryana’s Rewari.

The ex-servicemen were one constituency waiting to be tapped. Many of them were angry that the UPA had not delivered on its ‘one rank, one pension’ promise. Others were disappointed that the UPA hadn’t taken a tough stand on Pakistan. Retired generals would often come on prime-time television shows calling for ‘war’ with Pakistan.

One of the organizers of the Rewari rally was General V.K. Singh, who had retired as army chief after getting into a public row with the Manmohan Singh government. General Singh had political ambitions (he would eventually contest the Lok Sabha polls on a BJP ticket, win by the second highest margin after Modi and become a minister). Modi wanted the support of the men in uniform. It was a perfect match. In a fiery speech, he claimed that the country’s security problem was not on the borders, but in Delhi. ‘Till we have an efficient, patriotic government in Delhi, it doesn’t matter how capable our defence forces are!’ he thundered. No, he didn’t call for a war with Pakistan, and yes, he did conveniently forget the 1971 war under Indira Gandhi’s leadership when referring to military achievements. But the assembled crowd was impressed. *‘Dil se bol rahe hain’* (He is speaking from the heart), one of them told our reporter. If Modi was making a dent in Haryana, a state with a limited BJP base, then clearly there was a mood swing.

Over the next five months from September 2013 to February 2014, Modi addressed several such large rallies across the country, from Arunachal to Andhra Pradesh, from Mumbai to Meerut. In Hyderabad, he laced his speech with Telugu greetings; in Mumbai, with Marathi. Most of the speeches were on weekends, when television audiences are often at home. The standing joke in office was—if it is a Sunday afternoon, forget all other programming, there will always be a Modi rally to telecast live.